shared a record-breaking stand of 399 with Jonny Bairstow, whose unbeaten 150 was also a powerful statement of intent.

As strange as it seems, such startling statistics throw us off the scent. Stokesy is driven by the team, rather than obsessed by individual recognition. I genuinely don't think he cares about himself, so long as England are winning. That selflessness has turned him into the hardest-working England player in recent years, irrespective of the mistakes he has made growing up in public.

I wasn't in the West Indies in 2014 when he infamously broke his wrist punching a locker after getting out for 0 in the third one-day international in Antigua, but wasn't particularly surprised. His wildcat approach always had an element of self-reproach, and he impulsively abandoned a promising rugby-league career as a teenager.

Everyone tends to forget he played two T20 internationals on that tour, with his hand in bits. Peter Moores did the groundwork, helping him to channel his aggression positively, but lasting change comes from within. Lesser characters would have been intimidated by his implosion in the 2016 T20 World Cup final, when he conceded four successive sixes to give the West Indies an unlikely win, but he continued to front up.

Any team in an office, classroom or building site, works on human chemistry. The DNA of the team I eventually handed over to Joe Root in the spring of 2017 was unique, since no side is identical, but it contained a familiar balance of personalities. Moeen Ali, and to a slightly lesser extent Jos Buttler, emphasized its chilled, more free-spirited nature. They didn't want to win with any less fervour, but they were more relaxed about the process. Mo is particularly placid. I don't think I've ever seen him angry, except when Liverpool lose. The closest I've got to winding him up is by questioning his football pedigree and allegiance. He bites, gently, when you suggest he seems such a butterfly he was probably a Manchester United fan in his youth. When pressed, he will point you to a YouTube clip of him and Jimmy being given a tour of Anfield by Jürgen Klopp.

His cricket is a serious business. It runs through his family and radiates through his community. He is such an important figure as a man of faith and perspective. He has a fatalistic attitude that things are written. If he gets 0 today, it could be his destiny to score a century tomorrow. Succeeding does matter to him, profoundly, but he gives the impression it doesn't. His attitude that, 'Look, it's just a game of cricket,' has rubbed off on a few